



GRAPHICS CARDS

Graphics cards have come a long way from the good old days when they just had to have a little processing power and a few megabytes of RAM. The trend over the years has been to move much of the load of graphics processing and rendering from the CPU to the GPU. So much so, that today's graphics cards are heavy-duty number crunchers that use much more advanced technology than other parts of the computer system. Today you get graphics cards for almost every requirement—high-end or entry level—and at every level they come in a mind boggling variety, as compared to the few that were available just a while ago.

The 5900 Ultra is a gamer's delight. It has a mellowed down core clock speed of 450 MHz with the memory clock speed at 800 MHz, and also does not generate the amount of noise that its predecessor did. The video RAM has been doubled, and the card has an onboard video memory of 256 MB DDR. This is quite a large amount of memory, and is enough to future-proof you from any resource-hungry game that you throw at it. The card also supports

Gainward GeForce FX 5900 Ultra (256 MB)

- + Best performance
- Expensive, availability is low

Price: Rs 37,875

Contact: Mediatech India

Phone: 022-5639 6696

Fax: 022-2201 4083

E-mail: sales@mediatechindia.com

Reviewed in: October 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: Gainward GeForce4

2001: Asus V8200 GeForce Deluxe

hardware DirectX 9 and OpenGL 1.4, which means that games like the soon-to-be-released Half-Life 2 and Doom 3 will not only just play smoothly on this card, but also with all the eye-candy turned on, at high resolutions. This video card belongs to the reputed Golden Sample Category. This is a special line-up of cards that Gainward produces using the choicest of

WORTHY MENTIONS

Gainward GeForce FX 5900

- + Best value
 - No video-in
- Price:** Rs 23,950
Contact: Mediatech India
Phone: 022-5639 6696
Fax: 022-2201 4083
E-mail: sales@mediatechindia.com
Reviewed in: October 2003

Gigabyte Radeon 9600 Pro

- + 0.13 micron fabrication, four full DX9 pixel pipelines, two-vertex shader
 - Lower scores than nVidia 5600-based cards in Quake III Arena
- Price:** Rs 14,100
Contact: Digi-Giga Systems Ltd
Phone: 022-2652 6696
Fax: 022-2883 5886
E-mail: sales@dlinc.co.in
Reviewed in: October 2003

components so that the card is overclocker-friendly, and also gives maximum performance without being over-clocked. In our tests, this card was a clear winner.

INPUT DEVICES (GAMING)

The major players in the Indian gaming-devices market are Microsoft and Logitech, with awesome technologies and prices to match, while companies such as Saitek, Frontech and Typhoon provide the price-to-performance advantage.

The Precision 2 joystick is an affordable buy, but is packed to the brim with features.

The base is small, light and funky, and has a comfortable grip, thumb recess and a commendably-sized palm rest. While the button layout remains the same as its predecessor, one of the most promising differences from the Force Feedback 2 is its excellent throttle. The throttle has a sizeable amount of throw angle and so gives a very linear response—a very good feature, one that can make a lot of difference when playing flight simulators.

The base was redesigned and made smaller, so the Precision 2 weighs less and hampers stability to an extent. The rubber pegs manage to hold on to the surface, but the stick has a tendency to trip when jerked

Microsoft SideWinder Precision 2

- + Eight buttons, hat-switch, excellent throttle, third axis, good build quality
- Stick has a tendency to trip when jerked sideways

Price: Rs 1,200

Contact: Microsoft Corporation India Pvt Ltd

Phone: 1600-111 100

Fax: 011-2642 8540

E-mail: connect@microsoft.com

Reviewed in: March 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: NA

2001: NA

sideways. The presence of a third axis on this stick is laudable, considering the price.

What makes the Precision 2 stand apart from the competition is that at Rs 1,200, the eight buttons, hat-switch,

WORTHY MENTIONS

Logitech WingMan Formula Force GP

- + Rugged and non slippery, excellent force feedback
 - No gear paddle
- Price:** Rs 2,300
Contact: Aditya Infotech Ltd
Phone: 022-2880 1335
Fax: 022-2883 5886
E-mail: origin121@vsnl.com
Reviewed in: March 2003

Logitech WingMan Cordless Rumble Pad

- + 8 way movement, 2.4GHz RF signal with max distance of 20 feet, bundles four AA Duracell alkaline batteries
 - Quite heavy
- Price:** Rs 4,300
Contact: Aditya Infotech Ltd
Phone: 022-2880 1335
Fax: 022-2883 5886
E-mail: origin121@vsnl.com
Reviewed in: March 2003

excellent throttle, third axis and good build quality, are reasonably priced for the casual and amateur gamer alike.